

LEAVING CERTIFICATE GEOGRAPHY · 40% OF THE FINAL GRADE

Leaving Certificate Geography - Applied Geography Project Brief

Demo brief built from the NCCA Guidelines to support the Applied Geography Project (December 2025)

1. The theme: water - shaping our local area

Water shapes every community in Ireland. It fills our taps, powers and employs us, carves our river valleys, moves our coastlines and, increasingly, tests us - flooding homes and towns in one season and stressing supplies in the next. Climate change is making storms wetter and summers drier, so the way water behaves where you live is changing too.

For this project you will investigate one aspect of the theme where you actually live. Water is everywhere once you start looking: the river that floods the car park, the beach that retreats every winter, the limescale in the kettle, the canal behind the school, the burst pipe in the cold snap, the group water scheme in the countryside, the lifeguards on the strand in July.

- The theme is the focus of your project: your inquiry question must be directly related to it.
- You are strongly encouraged to choose a local focus or setting - it makes the inquiry manageable and the evidence real.

2. Getting started

Your teacher will introduce the brief and may facilitate a class discussion on the theme. Use the discussion to consider initial ideas, their feasibility and any limitations. From the very beginning, keep an inquiry log: a personal record of your approach, decisions (and your reasons), useful sources and evidence as you gather it. The inquiry log is not submitted to the SEC, but it is the engine of your report.

3. What you must do: the seven stages of the inquiry

The project runs through seven stages of geographical inquiry, in order. Indicative times are shown; the whole project is up to 20 hours.

- Stage 1 - Considering the brief (up to 1 hour): understand the theme, list your geographical questions, note possible local focuses.

- Stage 2 – Formulating the inquiry question (3-4 hours): background reading from reliable sources, then an inquiry question that is relevant to the theme, clear about what you are finding out and where, broken into sub-questions.
- Stage 3 – Considering evidence collection (2-3 hours): decide what primary and secondary evidence you need, justify your methods, plan to minimise bias, and consult your teacher on feasibility, safety, ethics and data protection.
- Stage 4 – Collecting evidence (6-8 hours): gather your own evidence, recorded in your inquiry log with dates, locations and conditions. Evidence must not be shared with peers.
- Stage 5 – Analysing and communicating (2-3 hours): find the patterns and trends, present evidence in justified formats (charts, graphs, tables, maps), and interpret what it all means for your inquiry question.
- Stage 6 – Evaluating evidence and reflecting on findings (1-2 hours): judge the reliability and accuracy of your method, consider bias, and reflect on the broader significance of your findings.
- Stage 7 – Finalising the report (up to 1 hour): assemble your authentic account into the digital report the SEC will mark.

4. Requirements

All work must be your own. You may work with others only when carrying out specific evidence-collection activities, but the evidence you use and the report you write are individual. Most work is completed in school under your teacher's supervision; if any part happens outside school hours or grounds, you need the necessary permissions and must follow ethical and safety guidelines agreed with your school.

You must consult with your teacher on the manageability and feasibility of your approach before you begin collecting evidence.

- Your inquiry question must be relevant to the theme, state what you are finding out, and name the setting.
- Evidence does not need to be collected at a single point in time; keep privacy and data protection (GDPR) in mind throughout.
- Projects do not always go as planned – documenting decisions and adaptations is valued, not penalised.
- Reference every source that is not your own, including any AI tools: the tool's name, the date, how it was used, and the shareable chat URL or the prompt used.
- The final report is submitted digitally in a format prescribed by the SEC – the instructions with this cycle's brief will set the word count, number of images, required structure and section headings.

5. Timeline

In the live examination cycle the real brief issues from the State Examinations Commission in Term 2 of Year 1 (spring of 5th year – spring 2027), and all work must be concluded by the date the SEC sets and communicates to schools. This demo brief stands in for that document so you can practise the process now.

6. Assessment

The Applied Geography Project is worth 40% of your Leaving Certificate Geography grade and is assessed solely on your individual report, at the level at which you sit the written examination. Examiners reward three things in the descriptors of quality: planning and conducting your inquiry, analysis and communication, and evaluation and reflection.

H1Done Projects · interactive mock-up · this document is a demo stand-in for the official SEC brief.